

"Living-Alone Girls' Lives Matter": Exploring the Security and Safety Perceptions and Practices of Young Women Living Alone in China

Shijing He*
King's College London
London, United Kingdom
shijing.he@kcl.ac.uk

Chenkai Ma*
King's College London
London, United Kingdom
chenkai.ma@kcl.ac.uk

Chi Zhang
University of St Andrews
St Andrews, United Kingdom
zhangchilindsay@gmail.com

Ruba Abu-Salma
King's College London
London, United Kingdom
ruba.abu-salma@kcl.ac.uk

Jose Such
King's College London
London, United Kingdom
VRAIN, Universitat Politècnica de
València
València, Spain
jose.such@kcl.ac.uk

Abstract

Increasing numbers of young women living alone face a wide range of security and safety (SS) concerns such as harassment, surveillance, and violence in today's China. Through thematic analysis and feminist critical discourse analysis (FCDA) of SS-related posts on RedNote ($n = 404$), a popular social platform in China, we uncovered the SS practices of living-alone women (e.g., deploying smart home devices, improving masculinity), and how social media amplifies fears, ignites feminist debates, and exacerbates gender inequality in China. Within China's unique socio-cultural environment—characterized by traditional gender norms, government surveillance, and the rapid adoption of surveillance technologies—we found that women's SS concerns are commodified, shifting responsibility onto individuals rather than driving systemic reforms. As a result, patriarchal power structures remain intact, while state and legal systems fail to address the root causes of violence.

CCS Concepts

• Security and privacy → Social aspects of security and privacy.

Keywords

Security, safety, feminism, gender inequality, discourse analysis, social media

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*Both authors contributed equally to this research.

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1 Introduction and Background

The concerns and needs related to women's security and safety (SS) have been explored in HCI research (e.g., [1, 2, 16, 18, 35, 56, 85, 93]). However, existing research lacks adequate exploration of women's SS issues in non-Western contexts, such as China, where distinct cultural and social dynamics exacerbate these concerns. Traditionally, Chinese families have been patriarchal and patrilineal, positioning women in subordinate roles [73]. The dualistic perspective of *yin* (feminine) and *yang* (masculine), traced back to the *Book of Changes* and reinforced by Confucianism [19], reinforced the inequality between women and men, portraying the former as natural preys and the latter as natural predators. Chinese feminist discourse also differs from its western counterpart due to historical and cultural factors (see §2).

Without the practical and emotional support that co-habitants may provide [89], women living alone in China (approximately 40 million, representing 2.83% of the population [51]) face increased risks of SS. A 2021 survey of 1,556 Chinese women living alone identified SS concerns as their primary issue [10]. Furthermore, incidents related to women's SS (for example, sexual harassment¹ and violent crimes²) have ignited widespread discussions about the everyday threats women encounter within the community. In response to growing SS concerns, a significant number of users have adopted smart home technologies, with over 78 million households using such devices by 2023 [63]. Moreover, feminism in China is closely intertwined with consumerism, framing women's empowerment and independence through the lens of consumption [72, 77, 81]. This alignment further reinforces the link between SS concerns and the adoption of SS-focused smart home devices.

¹In 2022, Tangshan city, nine men violently assaulted four women at a barbecue restaurant after one man's attempt to sexually harass one of them was met with resistance: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2022_Tangshan_restaurant_attack.

²A living-alone girl was murdered by a man who used a suitcase to move her body in Shanghai in 2021: https://www.sohu.com/a/495679964_400421.

Despite the increasing concern over women's SS in China and the crucial role of social media in feminist activism, there is a gap in research that specifically focuses on young Chinese women living alone and their perceptions and practices related to SS, especially considering China's unique socio-cultural and technological context [91]. Unlike in the West, where privacy concerns are at the forefront of surveillance debates, discussions in China often reveal a nuanced balance between the pursuit of security and the acceptance of technology-driven surveillance measures [90]. To better understand this, we gathered and thematically analyzed posts on RedNote related to SS practices and perceptions of young women living alone in China ($n = 404$).³ Our findings reveal that young women living alone in China frequently turn to smart home devices, particularly doorbells, door locks, and surveillance cameras, to address their SS concerns. Additionally, some adopt strategies to enhance masculinity, especially in relation to perceived threats from men (e.g., delivery workers). However, only a few rely on aspects of the Chinese culture to boost their sense of security, such as collecting *yang* energies to balance their *yin* energies. Furthermore, women's SS fears are commercialized, with their anxieties transformed into marketable products that exploit their insecurities. Social and cultural discourses, along with platform amplification, heighten fear, while economic hardship and inadequate privacy protections enable men (e.g., delivery workers) to access women's private information. Companies profit by offering security and surveillance products and linking feminism with consumerism, further deepening the commodification of safety for women living alone. As a result, these women are encouraged to adopt constant fear, anxiety, and surveillance solutions, while state and legal systems fail to address the root causes of violence. We stress the need for a feminist critique within Chinese social and cultural contexts, advocating not only for safer surveillance technologies and stricter regulations but also for broader societal transformation—reforming patriarchal power structures, challenging traditional gender hierarchies, de-commodifying safety, and holding offenders accountable.

2 Related Work

Research on women's SS has consistently highlighted the vulnerabilities they face in both public and private spheres. Public spaces often pose risks of harassment, stalking, and assault, requiring women to adopt various strategies to navigate these environments safely [20, 35, 58, 69]. Women also face unique challenges and threats to SS in private settings, including targeted burglaries, sensitive data breaches, unwanted surveillance, and domestic violence (e.g., [16, 46, 47, 60, 93]). These threats can not only cause physical harm, but can also significantly affect mental health, leading to increased anxiety, stress, and a sense of vulnerability [27, 28, 93]. In addition, smart home devices such as surveillance cameras, smart doorbells, and door locks have quickly gained popularity, offering users increased security and convenience. [68, 87]. People feel empowered by the ability to remotely monitor their homes and take immediate action if necessary [3]. However, smart home devices inherently involve trade-offs between privacy and security [4, 25, 70].

Users often tolerate a certain degree of surveillance in exchange for the perceived benefits of enhanced SS, reflecting the trade-off between the advantages of sharing personal information and the potential privacy and security risks involved [36, 40]. For women, this trade-off is considered acceptable when the perceived threat to physical safety surpasses concerns about privacy [11, 60, 65]. To mitigate these concerns, previous studies have also proposed technical interventions (e.g., [35, 52, 61, 85]). Furthermore, traditional gender norms often position women as “passengers” users in smart homes, with men dominating the implementation and management of smart home technologies [8, 11, 13, 22, 38, 39, 54, 65]. This dynamic can place women in vulnerable positions, as they may have limited control over the technologies intended to protect them and are often perceived as easier targets for crime [46].

In China, traditional gender norms continue to shape women's decisions regarding family and career, while also influencing public perceptions [17, 21, 24, 33, 86]. The state's recent emphasis on increasing birth rates has unintentionally reinforced traditional gender roles, positioning women primarily as reproductive instruments [92]. Women face unique challenges in addressing deeply rooted issues related to SS within Chinese society [45, 76, 80, 89]. Increased surveillance of women is sometimes justified by the notion that women are inherently vulnerable and therefore require special protection [7]. However, this perception can lead to victim-blaming, placing the responsibility for safety on women to protect themselves through technology rather than addressing the root causes of violence targeting women [55, 67]. Additionally, Chinese social networks serve a dual purpose: they enable the rapid spread of news about safety incidents while also providing a platform for user-generated content that addresses safety threats, such as sharing women's experiences, voicing concerns, and advocating for their rights [31, 48, 74]. Younger generations are increasingly utilizing social media to discuss challenges, seek support, and drive change [89]. However, government surveillance and regulations complicate efforts to advocate for women's rights [26, 53, 79]. In China, feminism is often treated as a sensitive term due to its association with western value systems [31] and is often criticized for allegedly promoting animosity toward men and advocating for women's rights at the expense of men's rights, without emphasizing the responsibilities that come with those rights [12, 48, 77, 82, 84]. Peng emphasized that the stigma associated with “feminism” further complicates the efforts of feminists to advocate for true equality [53]. For example, during the rise of the #MeToo movement in China in 2018, many hashtags related to reducing sexual violence and harassment were blocked [43]. The social media accounts of prominent feminists were subjected to strict surveillance, and some were permanently deleted [88, 89].

Summary. Despite the growing concern over women's SS needs in China and the vital role of social media in feminist activism, there is a lack of research focusing on SS perceptions and practices of young women living alone. Our study examines the experiences and challenges these women face, particularly their strategies and practices for raising SS awareness within their specific cultural and social contexts (e.g., using smart home devices). We highlight the intersection of consumer feminism and the tech industry's marketing strategies, illustrating how personal safety concerns, amplified through consumer choices, drive the domestic surveillance market.

³RedNote (Xiaohongshu) is a social media and e-commerce platform in China with 218 million monthly active users. Of these, 68% identify as female, and 50.5% are under 35 years old. Nearly half of its users live in China's first- and second-tier cities, with 90% of the content being user-generated [62].

3 Methodology

We gathered our dataset by scraping publicly available posts on RedNote. Since the content collected in this study was publicly available, it did not require approval from King’s Research Ethics Committee. However, given that the work involved individuals who could be considered at risk and included posts expressing negative experiences, careful measures were taken to ensure that no ethical issues arose. We removed all personally identifiable information (PII), including account IDs, IP locations,⁴ avatars, and account names. We anonymized and paraphrased all quotes to prevent reverse-searching [15].

3.1 Data Collection

The first author began by scanning posts on RedNote, collecting the hashtags listed in these posts, and identifying key hashtags ($n = 239$) related to our research focus. Two other authors then examined these initial key hashtags, and all three authors discussed and finalized the hashtag list ($n = 73$).⁵ We defined a valid post as one that discussed or provided advice related to the SS needs and/or concerns of young women living alone, addressing physical or mental concerns, or protection methods (e.g., those involving smart home devices). We scraped data from August 2024 to November 2024, utilizing MediaCrawler [49] to gather 1,523 relevant posts based on our hashtag list. The scraped data included the post ID and link, account name, user ID, post/edited post time, post IP location, counts of likes, collects, shares, and comments, as well as the textual content (including images). The first author eliminated all duplicate posts, leaving a total of 853 posts. The three authors then individually reviewed these posts and convened to discuss further inclusion and exclusion criteria. After several rounds of discussion, we agreed to exclude posts that: 1) contained videos; 2) did not offer any SS-related advice (e.g., posts about resisting surrogacy); 3) focused on physical safety but were more aligned with health-related advice (e.g., sexual health, hygiene); or 4) were advertisements, marketing materials, or promotional content about smart home devices. Our final sample included 404 relevant posts on RedNote.

3.2 Data Analysis

We inductively analyzed [6] the 404 posts we collected. For any images included in a post, we extracted text from them for analysis alongside the post’s written content. Additionally, we examined the images in their entirety, focusing on their visual information. To appropriately refer to gender, we used gender identities (man and woman) instead of biological classifications (male and female) [55]. Our codebook was iteratively developed and refined throughout the coding process. Initially, two researchers independently coded 20 randomly selected posts and developed separate codebooks. They met to resolve disagreements and merged their codebooks into one. They then independently coded another 50 posts to test the merged codebook, met again to resolve disagreements, and made further revisions. This process was repeated with another 50 new posts until code saturation was achieved. Once the codebook was

finalized, two researchers coded all posts and grouped the codes into themes. Three researchers then applied feminist critical discourse analysis (FCDA) [41] to examine perceptions, practices, and gender/sociopolitical dynamics related to SS issues. They examined discourse in the context of Chinese social and cultural norms, narratives, regulations, policies, and public attitudes toward technology and gender roles, continuously reviewing and refining their analysis through a feminist lens [5].

3.3 Author Positionality

According to the World Health Organization (WHO), the female homicide rate in China was 0.7 per 100,000 people in 2019, which was lower than in the UK (1), the US (2.2), and the global average (2.5) [71]. This may suggest that young women living alone in China face lower actual risks compared to many other countries or regions, which may be the result of powerful government policies or surveillance [66, 75]. However, a detailed investigation of the real risks faced by them is beyond the scope of this paper. Furthermore, although we used FCDA and relevant HCI analysis models [5, 41] to reduce potential researcher biases in data analysis, we recognize that our backgrounds and experiences could still shape our perspectives. Interdisciplinary collaboration between experienced researchers in human-centered computing—who have extensive experience working with at-risk groups—and social scientists specializing in politics and gender strengthened our ability to mitigate bias. Although all authors are currently affiliated with predominantly Western institutions, three data analysts, who were born and raised in China, provided a nuanced interpretation of the data. Additionally, four authors have extensive experience researching at-risk groups (e.g., women and migrants), while two specialize in examining SS concerns of Chinese female users and their unique needs on social media.

3.4 Limitations

This study has several limitations. First, our dataset focuses exclusively on data collected from RedNote, which skews the research toward the experiences of urban, young, and tech-savvy individuals, potentially overlooking the perspectives of women in rural / undeveloped areas, older women, or those less engaged with technology, thereby limiting its generalizability to the broader female population in China. Additionally, while some of the quotes we present may appear extreme (see §4), it is important to recognize that information on RedNote, along with our results and discussion, does not necessarily reflect reality. Rather, it represents users’ perceptions, which are shaped by the influence of RedNote’s recommendation algorithms. Second, RedNote posts may be subject to censorship by Chinese authorities based on the sensitivity of the content and the usage of words [55]. We observed instances where posts were blocked from access via desktop websites, and previously visible posts were later marked as invisible. Also, although our work is largely reproducible, the posts would no longer be available if their authors chose to delete them. Third, the data is based on self-reported posts and comments, which could be subject to social desirability bias or may not accurately reflect actual behaviors and attitudes [50].

⁴Provisions on the Management of Internet User Account Information require social media platforms in China to display users’ province-level IP addresses.

⁵Our finalized codebook and hashtag list can be found in [this OSF repository](#).

4 Results

In this section, we introduce the SS-related practices of young women living alone in China (e.g., enhancing perceived masculinity, adopting smart home devices) and examine their perceptions. We also explore how consumer feminism and surveillance capitalism influence the shaping of these practices.

Enhanced masculinity meant a sense of safety. Many posts suggested pretending to have a male cohabitant to deter potential intruders. The most common suggestions included placing men's shoes and clothes around the house, as well as playing or using men's voices, to create the impression of a male presence. However, some criticized this strategy, noting that some criminals may have realized that these shoes were “smoke bombs”. As R388 mentioned: “Creepy men can ‘evolve.’ They’ll sniff the shoes to see if they actually smell worn, trying to verify if a man really lives there.” Interestingly, R76 extended this concept to pets, suggesting: “Sisters, if you live alone, get a large, preferably male dog. Male dogs defend their territory more fiercely and can scare off an adult man.” Additionally, some posts emphasized the need for specific features in smart home devices to ensure security, as R200 stated: “We can choose smart cameras and doorbells with AI voice-changing features, then we can use a man’s voice to communicate with delivery guys.” Similarly, other posts recommended presenting oneself as male (e.g., using a male avatar) on delivery apps to avoid harassment from delivery workers. However, some argued that this trick had become too well-known to be effective. R17 suggested a more subtle approach: “Don’t use a man’s photo as your profile image — delivery guys all know that trick. Instead, in your delivery notes, write something like ‘Don’t knock or call, just leave it at the door. My wife does not let me order takeout; if she sees this, I am done.’” R397 further linked being “rude, irritable, and impatient” to a form of masculinity, stating: “Sisters, listen! We women should not feel like being impolite to male delivery workers is sinful. No one says you have to be polite to everyone. You have to act like a man, including being rude, irritable, and impatient, because it is likely the only way to keep you safe.”

Surveillance ensured safety. More than half of the posts recommended the use of smart home devices (e.g., smart home cameras, doorbells) to monitor entryways and detect suspicious activities. These devices were often framed as essential for maintaining personal safety. For example, R1 shared her negative experience and recommended that others use smart home devices (which received 88K likes, 18K collects, and 6.7K comments). R97 noted: “It is essential to install a smart camera or a doorbell! You never know who might knock on your door in the middle of the night. With these devices, you can monitor in real time and keep recordings as evidence of prosecution!” In addition to basic surveillance, some posts emphasized the need for advanced security features, including motion detection, 3D face recognition, authentication through both vein patterns and fingerprints, and infrared thermography. Some posts recommended smart home devices based on individual experiences: “The smart lock should be able to take photos and send real-time alerts to your phone if someone lingers outside your door or tries to open the lock. The material is also important; you must buy a C-level lock,⁶ and my current door lock is C-level. Do not compromise quality for a cheaper

plastic lock, as it will not provide sufficient strength against brute force attacks.” (R234)

Chinese cultural beliefs and social practices influenced SS. Many posts discussed how unique cultural factors (e.g., traditional Chinese worldviews, rituals, and deities) shaped young women’s strategies for addressing SS concerns while living alone. For instance, R312 discussed how to balance the energies “yin” and “yang” when living alone: “A great feng shui master says that when a woman lives alone, the yin energy in the room becomes too strong and the yang energy becomes too weak. To restore the yin-yang balance, which is essential for your safety and good luck, you need to light many candles in your room frequently or bathe in more sunshine. As long as you perform one of these things as instructed, no evil entities will come to your home and harm you. This is not a superstition.” R351 further mentioned, “Another good way is to have a partner with strong yang energy and live with him.” Others (e.g., R32) invoked traditional Chinese rituals and deities, including practices involving Menshen⁷ to protect their homes. Some posts also highlighted cultural perspectives on community harmony—a key Confucian value [42]. For example, R3 noted: “A good relationship with neighbors is the foundation of a fulfilling life for women living alone. As Chinese people, we know that a neighbor who is willing to help is often much more reliable than a husband. It’s also important to always keep the phone numbers of the local police station and medical emergency services in your community.” Furthermore, regarding phrases that could be considered politically sensitive, some posts abbreviated them, used pinyin instead,⁸ or substituted them with emojis, likely to avoid the widespread and unpredictable government censorship on Chinese social media [44]. For example, some of them used a police emoji or “JC” (an abbreviation of “jingcha”, which is the pinyin that means police) instead of Chinese characters (e.g., R38, R51, R171, R290). Similarly, other sensitive phrases, such as freedom (“ziyou”), independence (“duli”), and ID card (“shenfenzheng”), were all replaced with their pinyin (R37).

Androphobia and hyper-vigilance. Some posts revealed a high level of hyper-vigilance, with women often describing intense fear of unknown men or intruders, as R7 noted: “I would rather proudly sit in the defendant’s seat than lie dead in the coffin.” Some posts recommended constant vigilance, such as always avoiding disclosing that they lived alone and being cautious of unfamiliar individuals (especially men) who might pose a threat. These posts highlighted various self-protection tools, such as door blockers, portable alarms, and personal defense weapons (e.g., pepper spray, knives, Chinese cleavers) and offered advice on their use in emergencies, as R82 noted: “Although our upper body strength and muscle mass are generally less than men’s, using a small yet powerful tool like an electric saw can practically ensure a victory. It is crucial to understand that if a man forcibly enters our space, they likely intend to cause serious harm, even fatal. So, we must be prepared to respond decisively and without hesitation. Practicing with these tools beforehand is essential to ensure familiarity and confidence in their use.”

⁷Menshen, or gate deities, are supernatural figures in Chinese folk mythology that protect doors or gates. These deities are believed to protect evil entities or energies from entering the home. The most well-known Menshen characters are Qin Shubao and Yuchi Gong, both of whom are male deities.

⁸Pinyin is a Romanization system that uses the Latin alphabet to represent Mandarin Chinese sounds. Although it aids pronunciation, a single pinyin spelling can correspond to multiple characters with different meanings.

⁶GA/T 73-2015 classifies anti-theft mechanical locks into four security levels: Ordinary, A, B, and C, with C being the highest level of security.

Similar to R82, a few posts advocated for violent self-defense, as R97 noted: *“Any tool with sharp edges or spikes can be used as a self-defense tool to cause serious but necessary damage to all horrible men who just exist and wait there. Sisters, we are born brave, innately wise, and inherently strong!”* Notably, few posts suggested an extreme method, as R22 (received 28K likes, 11K collects, and 3K comments) stated: *“When a suspicious man rings the doorbell, boiling a pot of hot water is more effective than pretending there is a man living with you at home. Even more satisfying, put sugar and oil in a pot, heat it, and pour it over the intruder’s face! Melted sugar can stick hot oil on his face.”* R24 argued that, although these actions were extremely violent, they would not have legal consequences and should not provoke strong ethical concerns: *“If someone is truly attempting to break in, first call the police. Second, notify property management. Third, grab a sharp knife, hold it firmly, and securely tape it to your hand. When he breaks in, stab him wherever possible—it won’t cause you any trouble. I’ve spent a lot of money consulting multiple lawyers and surgeons. Don’t worry, every action we take will almost certainly be considered self-defense, and the intruder is unlikely to die. There’s no need to feel guilty or ashamed.”*

Criticism of society’s response to women’s SS needs. Despite that many posts shared practical SS suggestions about smart home devices and other methods to enhance perceived masculinity, some posts contended that such solutions ultimately failed to address the fundamental problem—society’s tendency to excuse or overlook criminal offenses toward female victims caused by males or men. For instance, R296 stated: *“All the popular safety advice I have seen on RedNote teaches us, women, how to appear more masculine. What has happened to our society that it has become so upside-down and insane? In this society, women are left with no option but to disguise themselves as men just to avoid harassment and harm from men. Disguise themselves as ‘men,’ whose claws we try so hard to escape from!”* R53 offered a broader critique of a social system that failed to prioritize women’s safety: *“Oh my! Someone marked my door with a triangle⁹ The apartment officers claimed that they checked the surveillance footage but did not find anything suspicious. I knew they did nothing, but they lied to my face! So I bought and installed my own smart video doorbell. This society definitely needs to teach men to respect women! Until that happens, the only protector of a woman is herself.”*

Based on these criticisms, some posts further expressed concern and doubt about the effectiveness of law enforcement and governments in protecting women from criminals. The authors of these posts believed that there would not be any fundamental, yet crucial, changes in public policy and societal attitudes in the foreseeable future and thus concluded that they could only rely on SS measures at the individual level. As R267 reflected on the Shanghai case that happened one year after the Tangshan case: *“It has been almost a year now, but I still don’t know what the final outcome will be. Will the man who killed that poor living alone lady be sentenced to death? Why have there always been so many dangers lurking in the dark, waiting for yet another woman victim? Sigh... I searched everywhere for hope, but all I could find were newspapers related to the Tangshan case. It is a relief that the murderer was caught. But what is next? No*

one knows. Perhaps the killer pulled some strings and ran away, as always.”

Feminism and consumerism. We found that many smart home devices were marketed as tools that empowered women by helping them manage their well-being, thereby creating and maintaining a sense of safety within their living spaces. This is especially appealing to young, urban women living alone, who are often financially able to invest in these technologies and place a high value on autonomy and independence. We found that many smart home device companies were capitalizing on this growing segment in the Chinese market, and leveraging consumer feminism to promote their products as essential tools for ensuring women’s safety and independence. For example, R182, a self-identified feminist with 426K followers, recommended that all her followers buy a doorbell priced at 848 CNY to improve their safety while living alone, even though similar products usually cost half as much. Some posts further emphasized the intersection of gender and economic inequality, revealing the broader implications of SS as a privilege rather than a right, with economic status playing a key role in one’s ability to feel safe and secure. For example, R99 discussed the practical and financial challenges involved in improving personal safety: *“Many women living alone are renters who recently moved out to live independently. It is difficult to get a smart doorlock each time someone moves to a new place. Ensuring safety while living alone in this way is often unaffordable and impractical for us.”*

5 Discussion and Conclusion

Our findings show that discussions on RedNote, along with the practices recommended by its users and market dynamics, reflect a deeply rooted sense of vulnerability among young women living alone in China. These factors collectively reinforce gendered power imbalances and increase anxiety about living alone, thereby intensifying the perceived need for smart home technologies, including surveillance, to provide assistance.

Our findings highlight the commodification of women’s concerns about living alone. Many posts acknowledged the benefits of widespread surveillance (e.g., CCTV cameras, police guardhouses¹⁰), the need for smart home devices, and roles of police and public security sectors in improving security and maintaining social stability [66, 78]. Chinese social norms and cultural expectations (e.g., Confucian values [57]) portray women as inherently vulnerable. Although socioeconomic conditions enable men (e.g., in the delivery industry [29]) to access women’s personally identifiable information (PII), companies can profit by offering surveillance devices [30], encouraging young women living alone to embrace anxiety, fear, and surveillance technologies. These external factors discourage women from critically reflecting on their own safety. In contrast, grassroots feminist movements that challenge authorities frequently encounter censorship, social platform restrictions, and societal pressures, such as stigmatization on social media [48]). Few voices advocate for change, let alone criticize the government or society. Our findings contribute to existing knowledge by highlighting how grassroots feminism challenges the hetero-patriarchal system

⁹Burglars and intruders may mark a house or apartment for future targeting; a triangle, for example, could indicate that it is occupied by a woman living alone: <https://www.abus.com/int/Guide/Burglary-protection/Secret-markings>.

¹⁰In April 2015, the General Offices of the CPC Central Committee and the State Council issued an opinion urging to strengthen protection and surveillance networks: https://www.gov.cn/xinwen/2015-04/13/content_2846013.htm.

in contexts where legal frameworks fail to provide the safety and security women need in an increasingly misogynistic society [83].

We highlight the role of social media in amplifying the fear experienced by women living alone. Fueled by some violent crimes against women living alone, such an echo chamber effect amplifies their anxiety and reinforces their perception of being vulnerable [9]. While posts promoting aggressive protection strategies or expressing negative emotions often received more engagement, re-posts featuring screenshots of extreme views helped perpetuate these narratives and intensify these emotions. These posts displayed strong solidarity among women, as they openly shared SS practices and encouraged others to adopt them (e.g., from installing smart home devices to adopting more masculine traits or even turning to superstition). This reflected a collective effort to navigate a society that is seen as increasingly hostile toward women [83]. Moreover, this fear has not only increased the demand for personal surveillance devices but also normalized their purchase and deployment. By recommending actions to counter potential threats, women's discussions unintentionally framed surveillance as both a necessary and desirable solution, often overlooking its associated costs. This normalization not only reflected but also perpetuated market-driven narratives that commodified women's anxieties, transforming their SS needs into profit opportunities, while reinforcing society's dependence on intrusive technologies. Smart home companies capitalize on widespread concerns about SS among women, promoting surveillance technologies as essential solutions [59], aligning women's empowerment and independence with the act of buying smart home devices, and reinforcing the idea that women's autonomy can be achieved through consumption [72, 77, 81]. However, these discussions ultimately normalize women's adaptation to insecurity, rather than addressing the root causes of gender inequality, such as systemic violence against women, legal shortcomings, or relevant socio-economic factors.

We also highlight a collective vigilance toward unfamiliar men, particularly delivery workers. This reflects broader socio-economic conditions, where economic downturns have left many young, working-age men in China unemployed,¹¹ pushing them into the gig economy, where they are compelled to rely on low-paying jobs with no social security and endure precarious working conditions and insufficient wages [34]. While creating millions of jobs, the rapidly expanding sector driven by e-commerce and food delivery platforms allows employees to access users' personally identifiable information (PII), gender, daily routines, and whether they live alone, thereby exposing young women living alone to potential risks. Due to insufficient regulations, these risks may materialize, compromising women's SS [32]. Our findings show that the protective measures suggested reinforce traditional gender norms and perpetuate stereotypes by portraying women as inevitable victims of violent crimes and placing the responsibility of SS solely on their shoulders [55, 67], further strengthening a form of commercialized safety and situating these practices within the framework of surveillance capitalism [94]. This narrative aligns with societal expectations in China, which emphasize that women must

take extra precautions to protect themselves rather than challenging the patriarchal power structures that create such vulnerabilities. Coupled with censorship, these discussions often sideline critical questions about why these measures are necessary in the first place, diverting public attention from the need for structural changes [23, 31, 76]. Such changes could include enhanced legal protections, non-discriminatory law enforcement, and community-based interventions that hold perpetrators accountable while actively working to reduce gender-based violence [14, 37].

Future research could expand our dataset to include additional Chinese social media platforms (e.g., TikTok, Weibo). By employing more quantitative methods, such as extracting statistics on topics, perspectives, narratives, and viewpoints from large volumes of texts, including news articles, blogs, reviews, and user comments, researchers could provide quantified evidence of how SS concerns among young Chinese women living alone relate to their mitigation practices (e.g., using smart home devices). This approach could also uncover the sentiments these discussions evoke within the online community. Furthermore, future studies could be extended to other contexts, including western countries, to offer a more comprehensive understanding of the SS challenges faced by young women living alone.

In summary, our results highlight deeply rooted societal issues shaped by cultural norms, socio-economic conditions, and technology. These findings call for a systemic re-examination of gendered power imbalances and a critical reconsideration of the reliance on surveillance devices as a solution to SS concerns. We emphasize the urgent need to move beyond focusing solely on safer technologies and more comprehensive regulations, as meaningful societal transformation requires a deeper exploration of patriarchal power structures and the dynamics of surveillance capitalism.

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¹¹China resumed publishing youth unemployment data in January 2024 after a six-month suspension, introducing a new methodology that excluded university students. As a result, the reported rate dropped to 17.1% in October 2024, compared to a record high of 21.3% in June 2023 [64].

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